

The one thing that unites young Indians' dreams for the country is an overwhelming belief in India's potential

who points out that while India is a country with many triumphs, its shortcomings can only be addressed through unity and respect for differences. Similarly, 17-year-old Riddhiman Ganguly, a student of Kolkata's St Claret School, has a strong vision for the future: "[An India] where the marble floors of the shrines are sacred, [but] so is all the land, water and air. I yearn for an India where the bovines are [seen as] divine and so are all other flora and fauna. I wish to see an India where the elite are respected, but so are the [destitute homeless]."

The varied nature of young dreams today is striking. "Children don't live isolated from what is going on in the country, or indeed the world anymore. Today, their knowledge base today is diverse and their goals can include just about anything," says Sunita George, principal of Bombay Scottish High School in Mumbai. Indeed, there are few topics left untouched by young people when it comes to expectations from India—self-reliance, quality education, a more positive media culture, less crime, sensitivity towards the marginalised, free speech, even a peaceful night's rest. The one thing that does unite their dreams for India is an overwhelming belief in the potential of the country. "My idea of India's future reflects the India of the past. One in which the country's genuine potential, its resources and people are recognised, valued and appreciated," says 21-year-old Kashish Mathur, a student of Amity Law School, Noida.

There also exists a belief that the India of tomorrow will be defined and improved by the youth of today. The growing participation of young people in addressing the country's problems can be seen in the sheer numbers that came out in support during the recent farmers' protests and the protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019. Vibhor Jain, a 19-year-old studying at IIT Delhi says that while democratically elected politicians may have forgotten the plight of our country, "the youth hasn't and will not forget India". And 16-year-old Radhika Bharadwaj, a student of Seth Anandram Jaipuria School in Ghaziabad adds, "The capable youth of India are coming to the rescue." It isn't just economic value that India's young demographic wishes to create but also cultural, social, environmental and political worth. ■